The BGS IV Corps, Brigadier K. K. Singh, would categorically maintain in later interviews, that it was the COAS, Thapar, and the DMO, Palit, who opted for Se-la as the defensive line against the advice of commanders on the spot.

The erstwhile GOC, Niranjan Prasad, had met Harbaksh at Dirang Dzong and briefed him independently of Palit. By the evening of 25 October, Harbaksh Singh put an end to all ambiguity, stating that the defensive line would indeed be drawn at Se-la. The corps commander then returned to Senge Dzong from where he left for Tezpur by helicopter.

Palit was relieved; his arguments in favour of Se-la had carried the day. Accompanying Palit on the trip to Dirang Dzong and Se-la was Major General Mohinder S. Pathania (Anant Pathania's cousin), who was at a loose end as he waited in Tezpur to take command of 2 Division that was being hurriedly raised for the defence of the Lohit Valley. As soon as Harbaksh Singh had taken off from Senge Dzong, Mohinder took Palit aside and told him that Anant was not at all happy about being stationed at such a high altitude and was in fact considering locating his Division HQ at Dirang, which was at a height of only 4,900 feet.

Palit now had a talk with Anant Pathania to convince him of the tactical sense of staying at Se-la. Describing the scene, Palit says: 'I spoke at length to Anant about the tactical and logistical potential of the Senge-Se-la complex and stressed that the camp we were at was the ideal place for his Division HQ. "You can direct the battle from here as well as keep an eye on the stocking up process. So long as you remain here, sitting astride this road, no one is going to retreat beyond this point. You establish yourself here, Anant, and we will send you all your requirements," I assured him. I cautioned him to secure the heights overlooking the passes he held, such as Kya-la and Poshing-la.'

Ever since the morning of 23 October the army chief had virtually abrogated all tactical decision-making pertaining to NEFA to his DMO—his role seems to have been confined to finding replacements for officers who had to be sacked after the Nam Ka Chu debacle. Showing rare guts in the face of perceived opinion, the chief had taken the decision to replace Bijji Kaul as the IV Corps Commander with Harbaksh Singh. His next choice, however, was not as inspired, for to all officers and men present at Se-la Top on 25 October, one thing was quite obvious: the new GOC of 4 Division, Anant Pathania, did not want to be there. For a GOC of a division